

GLOSSARY

This glossary is meant to be a comprehensive resource that you can go to when you have a question about Web design. Even if a topic may not be covered exhaustively in the book, we include it here to give you the important distinctions you need to get your job done.

24/7 • Twenty-four hours a day, seven days a week. Usually this term refers to the reliability of a system, one that cannot fail under any circumstances. Sometimes found as *24/7/365*, meaning 365 days a year as well. Also found as *24/7/360*, meaning 360 degrees around the globe.

A

accelerator • A way to speed up a task for the customer, such as a keyboard shortcut, a macro, or automatic storage of information.

access provider • See *Internet service provider*.

account management system • Any system designed to help people manage the personal information stored by a Web site. For more information, see ACCOUNT MANAGEMENT (H4).

H4

acquisition cost • The cost to acquire a new customer.

Active Server Pages • See *ASP* (definition 1).

Adobe Illustrator • A graphic design software tool that is useful for creating high-fidelity prototypes.

3

affinity diagramming • A way of organizing data in which all the individual points and concepts that have been gathered are arranged on a wall-sized, hierarchical diagram. For an example, see Figure 3.4 in Chapter 3 (Knowing Your Customers: Principles and Techniques).

affordance • A clue, often visual, to how an object works. For example, most door handles provide an affordance for grasping. Buttons in modern graphical user interfaces, such as action buttons, look three-dimensional, providing affordances for pushing.

For more information, see **SITE ACCESSIBILITY (B9)**, **DIRECT MANIPULATION (H9)**, and **ACTION BUTTONS (K4)**.

AJAX • Asynchronous JavaScript And XML, a set of technologies that enables the creation of Rich Internet Applications that have high levels of interactivity. For more information, see **WEB APPS THAT WORK (A10)**, **BROWSABLE CONTENT (B2)**, **DIRECT MANIPULATION (H9)**, **CLEAR FORMS (H10)**, **PREDICTIVE INPUT (H11)**, **DRILL-DOWN OPTIONS (H12)**, and **FAST-LOADING CONTENT (L6)**, and **MOBILE INPUT CONTROLS (M2)**.

alert • A brief message that notifies a customer of special events that may be of interest, such as the imminent due date of a library book or a particular stock's price drop below a certain mark. Compare *focused advertisement* and *newsletter*. For more information, see **E-MAIL SUBSCRIPTIONS (E2)**.

alpha • Referring to the first cut of a Web site created in the Implementation phase of Web development. An alpha version of a site contains basic functionality and major page types but is not yet polished or ready to be deployed. Compare *beta*.

<alt> text • Text that appears before an image is loaded, when an image is rolled over with the mouse, and if an image fails to load and is not being displayed. For more information, see **WRITING FOR SEARCH ENGINES (D6)** and **FAST-LOADING IMAGES (L2)**.

anchor text • The hypertext label that is used to link to a particular page.

antialiasing • Smoothing out jagged edges in images or fonts, creating gradual transitions instead of sharp transitions on the borders of images. Antialiased images usually look more professional, but they take a little more time to produce than unantialiased images.

Apache • One of the most popular Web servers. Apache is an example of open-source software.

API • Application programming interface, the means for using an existing piece of software in the source code for a new piece of software.

application programming interface • See *API*.

application service provider • Sometimes abbreviated *ASP*, a Web site or company that provides individuals or enterprises access over the Internet to applications and related services that would otherwise have to be located in their own personal or enterprise computers. Some ASPs focus on providing highly specific services that can be integrated into another Web site, such as search engines or providers of stock information. ASP can be used to outsource certain functions of a Web site, such as local search functionality, thereby making it easier to add the search function to a Web site.

ASP • (pronounced by speaking each letter individually) 1. Active Server Pages, a technology created by Microsoft that mixes HTML and software code. The code is executed when a client Web browser makes a request, enabling the creation of dynamically generated HTML. Compare *JSP*, a competing Java-based technology, and *PHP*, a competing Perl-based technology. 2. See *application service provider*.

asynchronous communication • A communications setup in which customers can leave messages that others can respond to later, such as in e-mail or on a message board. Compare *synchronous communication*. For more information, see **COMMUNITY CONFERENCE (A3)**.

Asynchronous JavaScript And XML • See *AJAX*.

authentication • A process that proves a person really is who he or she claims to be. One example of an authentication process is the use of passwords. Compare *identification*. For more information, see *PERSISTENT CUSTOMER SESSIONS* (H5).

H5

automated online research • Methods for querying hundreds of people (or more) automatically, to gather their attitudes, intentions, behavior, and performance on a Web site. For more information, see Appendix E (Online Research).

H6

automatic floating window • A floating window that appears simply as a result of a customer's arrival at or departure from a Web site. Automatic floating windows usually contain advertisements or surveys for improving the quality of a Web site. Compare *link-based floating window*. For more information, see *FLOATING WINDOWS* (H6).

B

b2b • Business-to-business. In e-commerce, a b2b business sells products or services to another business.

b2c • Business-to-customer. In e-commerce, a b2c business sells products or services to end customers or consumers.

b2e • Business-to-employee. In e-commerce, a b2e business provides services and productivity applications online to employees.

b2g • Business-to-government. In e-commerce, a b2g business sells products or services to the government.

1

back-end cost • A cost incurred as a result of responding to customer needs not addressed by the basic Web site—for example, through support calls, returns, and the like. For more information, see Chapter 1 (Customer-Centered Web Design: More Than a Good Idea).

bandwidth • A measure of data transmission speeds over a network connection. Bandwidth is often measured in kilobits per second (kbps) or megabits per second (mbps). Typical modem speeds are 28.8 kbps and 56 kbps. Bandwidth should not be confused with *latency*, which refers to the amount of time it takes to transfer data from one point to another. See also *broadband*, *cable modem*, and *DSL*.

banner ad • A small horizontal advertisement, usually at the top of a homepage. Visitors click it to link to a Web site. Banner ads are often animated and have standard sizes. Most advertisements on Web pages are banner ads.

beta • Referring to the second version of a Web site, created in the Implementation phase of Web development. It contains nearly all of the desired functionality and is more polished than the *alpha* release.

between-groups experiment • An experiment in which the pool of test participants is divided into two groups and each group is assigned to a different condition. For example, if there are two different Web sites to test, each participant uses only one of the two sites. Compare *within-groups experiment*. For more information, see Appendix A (Running Usability Evaluations).

E9

biometrics • A security alternative to simple passwords in which the computer uses a physical attribute such as a person's fingerprint to verify identity. For more information, see *PREVENTING PHISHING SCAMS* (E9).

bits per second (bps) • A measure of bandwidth. See *bandwidth* and *latency*.

blog • An abbreviation for *Web log*, a blog is a Web page with dated entries. Blogs are used for a variety of genres, including personal diaries, describing new services provided by a Web site, providing internal communications to employees, and aggregating news, to name just a few. For more information, see **BLOGS (A12)**.

blurb • A continuation of the headline on a Web page. A blurb provides details of the customer benefit, reinforcing what is important and unique about the content. Blurbs must be short and precise, not more than one or two sentences. Compare *headline*. For more information, see **HEADLINES AND BLURBS (D3)**.

bookmark • A mechanism built into most Web browsers that saves the location of a Web page so that the customer will not need to type in the address each time. Also called *favorite*. For more information, see **DISTINCTIVE HTML TITLES (D9)**.

Boolean search • A search that uses the term *and* or *or*. For example, the search “computer and monitor” would find all Web pages containing both *computer* and *monitor*, whereas “computer or monitor” would find all Web pages containing either *computer* or *monitor*. For more information, see **STRAIGHTFORWARD SEARCH FORMS (J2)**.

bot • Short for *robot*, a bot is a software program that does a repetitive action. Typically carrying a negative connotation, bots are used for things like spamming MESSAGE BOARDS (D5), signing up for thousands of e-mail addresses (which are later used for e-mail spam), and so on. For more information, see **BLOGS (A12)**.

bottom-line data • Quantitative usability data, often collected in later stages of design. Examples include time to complete a task, number of errors made, rate of learning, and retention of learned material over time. Compare *process data*. For more information, see Chapter 4 (Involving Customers with Iterative Design) and Appendix A (Running Usability Evaluations).

bps • See *bits per second*.

brand • What customers remember or feel about a Web site or the company behind it. Brand can be shaped by images, graphic look, or the logo of a company. For more information, see **SITE BRANDING (E1)**.

bread crumb • A small navigation cue giving some indication of where a visitor is currently located on a Web site and where he or she came from. Also called *trail marker*. For more information, see **LOCATION BREAD CRUMBS (K6)**.

brick-and-mortar • Referring to a company that has a strong real-world presence but a weak or no Web presence. Compare *click-and-mortar* and *e-tailer*.

broadband • Referring to a network connection with high bandwidth, such as DSL or cable modem. Typical speeds range from 256 kbps to 2 mbps.

brochureware • A derisive term for a simple Web site that does no more than promote a company and its products. For more information, see Chapter 1 (Customer-Centered Web Design: More Than a Good Idea).

browser • See *Web browser*.

browsing • One of two major strategies that visitors use to find information on a Web site, in which they examine pages and click on links that seem to take them

closer to their target Web page (regardless of whether that page actually exists).
B2 Compare *searching*. For more information, see BROWSABLE CONTENT (B2).

bug report • A report of a problem that is provided in a customer e-mail, a Web site evaluation, quality assurance testing, or server log file analysis.

5 **business analysis document** • A document, produced during the Discovery phase of Web development, that spells out the business needs of both the client and the customers. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites).

5 **business plan** • A high-level proposal that spells out a company's business model, the basic strategy for how a company will make money. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites).

C

cable modem • A form of broadband communication that transfers data across a cable television network. Compare *DSL*.

L5 **cache** • 1. To store information nearby. 2. The space used to store cached information. Web browsers cache Web pages that visitors have already seen so that the pages will load more quickly if viewed again. For more information, see REUSABLE IMAGES (L5).

H2 D5 **CAPTCHA** • Short for *completely automated public Turing test to tell computers and humans apart*, a CAPTCHA is a computer test meant to distinguish between humans and computers. A typical example is to discern letters within a distorted image, something that is relatively easy for people to do but difficult for modern computer systems. CAPTCHAs are used to prevent *bots* from completing SIGN-IN/NEW ACCOUNT (H2) processes or adding spam to MESSAGE BOARDS (D5). Sometimes called *human interactive proof* (HIP).

3 **card sorting** • A method of categorization by which customers help you organize and label large groups of content. Simply put, customers are asked to organize cards labeled with site content into stacks. For more information, see Chapter 3 (Knowing Your Customers: Principles and Techniques).

D11 **Cascading Style Sheets (CSS)** • A language for specifying how to present the information in an HTML Web page. With CSS, designers can control things like layout, fonts, and colors without modifying individual Web pages directly. For more information, see STYLE SHEETS (D11).

B3 K11 **category description** • A technique for testing the usefulness and usability of link names, independent of visual design and layout, in which participants are asked to describe what they think a given category contains. Compare *category identification*. For more information, see HIERARCHICAL ORGANIZATION (B3) and FAMILIAR LANGUAGE (K11).

B3 K11 **category identification** • A technique for testing the usefulness and usability of link names, independent of visual design and layout, in which participants are given a list of category names and a list of tasks, and are asked to choose the category that they think would help them complete each task. Compare *category description*. For more information, see HIERARCHICAL ORGANIZATION (B3) and FAMILIAR LANGUAGE (K11).

certification authority • A trusted third-party vendor that issues digital certificates for Web servers. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites).

5

CGI • See *Common Gateway Interface*.

click-and-mortar • Referring to a company that has both a strong Web presence and a strong real-world presence. Compare *brick-and-mortar* and *e-tailer*.

clickstream • The click path or page path that visitors take when they go through a site. Some server log tools and online usability research applications provide clickstream analysis tools. For more information, see Appendix E (Online Research).

click-through • The number of visitors who click on a banner ad. Usually expressed as a percentage, click-through is calculated as the total number of banner ads clicked on, divided by the total number of banner ads displayed. See also *CPM*.

client • 1. The specific computer or software that requests information, or any other resource, from a server. Web browsers are the most common clients. Compare *server*. See also *client-server architecture* and *Web browser*. 2. A person or company for whom you're doing Web design and development work; the person (company) providing the funding. Compare *customer*.

client-server architecture • A common form of software architecture in which a server contains information or other resources, and clients request the information or resources. The Web is an example of client-server architecture. Compare *peer-to-peer architecture*.

Common Gateway Interface (CGI) • The standard way of processing Web-based forms. CGI is also used to create dynamically generated HTML. Programming languages used for CGI include Perl, Python, and Java. Alternatives to CGI are the ASP, JSP, and PHP technologies.

community • A group of people tied together by shared interests or common values. For more information, see COMMUNITY CONFERENCE (A3), MESSAGE BOARDS (D5), and RECOMMENDATION COMMUNITY (G4).

A3 D5
G4

company-centered design • A design strategy in which the needs and interests of the company dominate the structure and content of the Web site. Compare *customer-centered design*, *designer-centered design*, and *technology-centered design*. For more information, see Chapter 1 (Customer-Centered Web Design: More Than a Good Idea).

1

competitive analysis • An analysis that evaluates competitors' Web sites, including the features they offer, as well as which features are important to customers and which are not. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites).

5

compressing • An approach to reducing the file size of an image in which either redundant information is encoded more compactly or the number of colors is reduced, thereby reducing the amount of information required to encode the image. Compare *cropping* and *shrinking*. For more information, see FAST-LOADING IMAGES (L2).

L2

conversion rate • A value representing the number of visitors who become buying customers on a Web site. Usually expressed as a percentage, the conversion rate is calculated as the total number of unique customers, divided by the total number of unique visitors. Higher conversion rates are better than low ones.



cookie • A browser feature that allows Web sites to keep information on a visitor's computer. Typically cookies are used for personalization, but they can also be used for tracking a customer's movements through the Web. For this reason, cookies are at the center of a growing privacy debate. For more information, see PERSONALIZED CONTENT (D4), PERSISTENT CUSTOMER SESSIONS (H5), FAIR INFORMATION PRACTICES (E3), and PRIVACY POLICY (E4).

CPM • Cost per thousand impressions. CPM is the cost per 1,000 people delivered by a medium or media schedule. For banner ads, CPM is the cost per 1,000 ads seen by visitors. See also *click-through*.



crawler • A program that gathers and processes content for later use by starting from a list of a few sites and going from link to link, opening pages and indexing the words on those pages. Crawlers make use of meta-information about the content, as well as the content itself, to create a search index. Also called *spider*. For more information, see WRITING FOR SEARCH ENGINES (D6).



critical incident • An incident during a usability test, in which the participant has either a positive or a negative reaction. Negative reactions include frustration, anger, or confusion during a task. Expletives can be strong indicators of negative critical incidents. Positive reactions include cases in which people are pleasantly surprised or say something positive about the site. For more information, see Chapter 4 (Involving Customers with Iterative Design) and Appendix A (Running Usability Evaluations).



CRM • Customer relationship management—methods and software to manage the long-term relationship between a company and a customer.



cropping • An approach to reducing the file size of an image in which unneeded portions of the image are trimmed. Compare *compressing* and *shrinking*. For more information, see FAST-LOADING IMAGES (L2).

cross-selling • Promoting products related to those that a customer already wants to purchase. Compare *up-selling*. For more information, see SHOPPING CART (F3) and CROSS-SELLING AND UP-SELLING (G2).

cross-tabulation • A method of evaluating research results in which answers from respondents are compared with the key questions in the research, and the results are viewed side by side. For more information, see Appendix E (Online Research).

CSS • See *Cascading Style Sheets*.

customer • A person who will use the Web site that you're designing. Also called *target customer*. Compare *client* (definition 2).



customer analysis document • A document, developed during the Discovery phase of Web development, that provides a deep understanding of the needs, tools, and existing practices of a Web site's target customers. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites).

customer-centered design • A design strategy that (1) focuses on understanding people, their tasks, the technology available, and the larger social and organizational context of where they live, work, and play; (2) keeps the customer involved in the design process; and (3) elicits from visitors to a Web site consistently high marks

for content, ease of use, performance, trustworthiness, and overall satisfaction—that is, it provides a positive experience for all customers, whether they're there to find information, to be part of a community, to purchase items, or to be entertained. Compare *company-centered design*, *designer-centered design*, and *technology-centered design*. For more information, see Chapter 1 (Customer-Centered Web Design: More Than a Good Idea).

1

customer-centered Web site • A Web site that provides real value and delivers a positive customer experience. Customer-centered Web sites receive consistently high marks for content, ease of use, performance, trustworthiness, and overall satisfaction from visitors. For more information, see Chapter 1 (Customer-Centered Web Design: More Than a Good Idea).

1

customer experience • The whole experience that a customer has, both online and offline, when using a Web site. Customer experience includes such online factors as ease of use and content, as well as offline factors such as fulfillment and customer service.

customer relationship management • See *CRM*.

customer session • A set of interactions by a customer with a Web site during one sitting. Web servers typically use cookies to track who the customer is and what he or she did on-site during the session. For more information, see PERSONALIZED CONTENT (D4) and PERSISTENT CUSTOMER SESSIONS (H5).

D4 H5

customization • A customer-driven process in which customers enter data and change the layout of a Web site to fit their tastes and interests. Customization is one way of achieving *personalization*. For more information, see HOMEPAGE PORTAL (C1), PERSONALIZED CONTENT (D4), and DIRECT MANIPULATION (H9).

C1
D4 H9

D

default setting • The normal setting for something, before a customer changes it.

deliverable • The end product of a milestone phase (Discovery, Exploration, Refinement, Production, Implementation, Launch, or Maintenance) of Web development. Common deliverables include interactive prototypes and specification documents.

demographics • Detailed characteristics of customers, such as age, education, income, and hobbies. Compare *psychographics*.

design document • A document, created during the Production phase of Web development, that describes how a Web site works in great detail and uses site maps, storyboards, and schematics to describe the flow of interaction. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites).

5

designer-centered design • A design strategy in which the needs and desires of the designer, not necessarily of the customers, dominate the structure and content of the Web site. Compare *company-centered design*, *customer-centered design*, and *technology-centered design*. For more information, see Chapter 1 (Customer-Centered Web Design: More Than a Good Idea).

1

design guidelines • See *guidelines*.

design style guide • General rules for site design that are intended to be followed on every Web page to minimize inconsistencies.

desktop metaphor • The conceptual model around which modern computer interfaces are organized, consisting of files, folders, trash cans, and so on. See also *GUI*.

DHTML • See *Dynamic HTML*.

digital certificate • Proof that a Web server has the identity it says it has. Digital certificates are issued by a variety of certification authorities. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites).

5

Digital Subscriber Line • See *DSL*.

directory • A form of organizing information, in which content appears in categories, usually alphabetically, sequentially, or hierarchically. The best-known example of a directory is Yahoo! Also called *index*. For more information, see GRASSROOTS INFORMATION SITES (A6) and HIERARCHICAL ORGANIZATION (B3).

A6 B3

Discovery phase • The first phase of Web development, in which the designer defines the design problem, and the designer and the client come to an agreement about the Web site's overall goals. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites). See also *Exploration phase*, *Refinement phase*, *Production phase*, *Implementation phase*, *Launch phase*, and *Maintenance phase*.

5

disintermediation • The removal of middlemen. For example, e-commerce can simplify the ordering and distribution of products by giving customers a direct line to the manufacturer. All the people who distribute the product to local stores, and all of the local stores, are removed.

Document Object Model (DOM) • A standard way of representing HTML and XML documents as objects that can be manipulated in programming languages. Developed by W3C as an open standard.

document type definition • See *DTD*.

DOM • See *Document Object Model*.

domain name • Technically, a way to name computers on the Internet. It is more common to use the domain name to identify a Web site, such as berkeley.edu, than to use its numerical IP address.

DSL • Digital Subscriber Line, a form of broadband network connection for the home that uses existing telephone lines. Compare *cable modem*.

DTD • Document type definition, a specification that accompanies a document and identifies the codes that separate paragraphs, identify topic headings, and so forth, as well as how each is to be processed. For example, a DTD is used by HTML and XML to define tags such as <html> and , and to define any tag-ordering constraints.

Dynamic HTML (DHTML) • Not to be confused with *dynamically generated HTML*, DHTML uses the Document Object Model to dynamically change Web pages after they have been downloaded to a customer's browser.

dynamically generated HTML • A Web page that is generated on the fly when a visitor requests it. The HTML in the Web page does not fully exist until the request is made. A simple use of dynamically generated HTML is to include the last time the HTML file was updated. A more sophisticated use is to provide personalization. Usually dynamically generated HTML is created by the use of CGI, ASP, JSP, or PHP. Dynamically generated HTML should not be confused with *Dynamic HTML*, a Web standard that is being developed by W3C.

E

e-commerce • The business of selling products or services online. The two major forms of e-commerce are business-to-business (b2b) and business-to-consumer (b2c). For more information, see PERSONAL E-COMMERCE (A1) and Pattern Group G (Advanced E-Commerce).

A1 G

embedded link • A link that is contained in the body of a text (as opposed to being listed at the end of an article). For more information, see INVERTED-PYRAMID WRITING STYLE (D7) and EMBEDDED LINKS (K7).

D7 K7

encryption • Translation of data into a secret form so that unauthorized people cannot easily understand it. SSL is a way of encrypting information transferred over the Web. For more information, see SECURE CONNECTIONS (E6).

E6

e-tailer • Short for *electronic retailer*, an e-tailer is a company that sells products online exclusively. Compare *brick-and-mortar* and *click-and-mortar*.

ethnography • A formal technique used in sociology and anthropology to observe and interact with people in their normal environments. See also *field observation*.

Exploration phase • The second phase of Web development, following Discovery, in which the developer generates multiple designs. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites). See also *Discovery phase*, *Refinement phase*, *Production phase*, *Implementation phase*, *Launch phase*, and *Maintenance phase*.

5

Extensible Markup Language • See *XML*.

Extensible Hypertext Markup Language • See *XHTML*.

extranet • A private portion of a company's Web site intended for suppliers, vendors, partners, and customers. An extranet can also be an extension of a company's intranet. Compare *intranet*.

F

false positive • A problem with a Web site interface that is identified by heuristic evaluation but never found to exist in a usability study of the same interface.

FAQ • Literally, frequently asked questions. A FAQ page provides answers to questions commonly asked by visitors to a Web site. For more information, see FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS (H7).

H7

favorite • See *bookmark*.

field observation • An experimental technique in which people are watched in their own environment, at home or at work, to see how they use a Web site and other tools, as well as how they interact with other people in their environment.

firewall • A proxy that limits the kind of information transferred over a network. Companies often use firewalls to protect their computers from unauthorized external access.

first read • The dominant visual element of a Web page that draws the customer's eyes. For more information, see HOMEPAGE PORTAL (C1) and CLEAR FIRST READS (I3).

C1 I3

Fitts's Law • An empirically determined law used to calculate the time it takes to move from a given point to a target object. Intuitively, the law states that objects

that are far away or small take longer to point to than objects that are close or large. Fitts's Law has implications for the size of clickable links and images.

3 For more information, see Chapter 3 (Knowing Your Customers: Principles and Techniques) and ACTION BUTTONS (K4).

K4 **five-way joystick** • A small joystick on a mobile phone or other mobile device that provides up, down, left, and right options, as well as a “select” option, when pushed.

five-way rocker switch • A small button or two on a mobile phone or other mobile device that can be pushed on different sides, providing up, down, left, and right options, as well as a “select” option, when pushed.

Flash • The tool and the browser plug-in, developed by Macromedia, for creating and viewing interactive multimedia presentations.

floating window • A small window that appears on the screen without creating a new browser window, and that seems to float over the current Web site. For more information, see FLOATING WINDOWS (H6).

H6 **flow** • 1. An interaction sequence through or navigation structure of a Web site, often illustrated with a storyboard. 2. Natural and easy movement of a customer on your Web site from goals to fulfillment of those goals.

E2 **focused advertisement** • An advertisement that draws attention to a new promotion, special offer, or new product. Compare *alert* and *newsletter*. For more information, see E-MAIL SUBSCRIPTIONS (E2).

3 **focus group** • A group of representative target customers who are gathered to provide feedback on their motivation for visiting a Web site, describe their response to it, and identify the tasks they want to accomplish there. For more information, see Chapter 3 (Knowing Your Customers: Principles and Techniques).

I2 **fold** • An imaginary line on a Web page that delineates what is visible in a browser without making the visitor scroll down. The content below the line is “below the fold.” Because a potential customer may not necessarily see content below the fold at first, the most important information should be placed above it. For more information, see ABOVE THE FOLD (I2).

force • A key issue or constraint that comes into play when you're trying to solve a particular design problem.

frequently asked questions • See *FAQ*.

fulfillment • All of the surrounding processes required to deliver and support products that customers have purchased, including logistics, inventory management, parcel management, and customer service. Fulfillment is a component of back-end costs.

G

L2 **GIF** • (pronounced “jiff” or “giff”) Graphics Interchange Format, a widely supported and popular way to store images. GIF is usually used for small images and images requiring transparency. See also *JPEG*, *PNG*, and *SVG*. For more information, see FAST-LOADING IMAGES (L2).

gold-plating • Trying to get a Web site absolutely perfect before launch.

graphical user interface • See *GUI*.

graphic design • Visual communication of information, using elements such as color, images, typography, and layout. Also called *visual design*. Compare *navigation design*.

Graphics Interchange Format • See *GIF*.

greeking • A visual design and usability testing technique in which nonsense text is placed on a Web page. Greeking allows those who view a design or participants testing the interface to focus on the layout and visual design of a page, instead of its content. Typical tasks that participants are asked to do on a greeked page include pointing to what they think is the page title, and pointing to what they believe are the news items. Greeking is often used in low-fidelity prototypes. For more information, see **GRID LAYOUT (I1)**.

grid layout • A technique for organizing Web pages that is borrowed from graphic design (where it is used for organizing page layouts for newspapers, magazines, and other documents), or the end result of that technique. In a grid layout, a page is divided into rows and columns, and every element is made to fit within this grid. Constant design elements, such as titles and logos, always appear in the same place, giving a consistent theme to every page. For more information, see **GRID LAYOUT (I1)**.

GUI • (pronounced “gooey”) Graphical user interface. This term often refers to the desktop interface, such as the interface found in Microsoft Windows or the Macintosh operating system. However, GUI can refer to any interface that uses graphics. See also *desktop metaphor*.

guidelines • Suggestions for how to build a Web site, but not as detailed or as rigid as specifications. Guidelines do not have to be as comprehensive, and they can leave more details to your discretion. Compare *specification document*. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites).

H

Handheld Device Markup Language • See *HDML*.

HCI • Human–computer interaction, a discipline concerned with the design, evaluation, and implementation of interactive computing systems for human use and with the study of major phenomena surrounding them. HCI includes a multitude of other disciplines, such as user interface design, the study of group work, human factors, human physiology, cognitive modeling, and universal accessibility.

HDML • Handheld Device Markup Language. Similar to HTML, HDML is a way to format information for small devices, such as mobile phones. WML is considered the successor to HDML. For more information, see **SITE ACCESSIBILITY (B9)**.

headline • A sentence fragment, roughly ten words or less so that it can appear in large type in a small space, that articulates a Web page’s hook in the shortest form possible. Compare *blurb*. For more information, see **HEADLINES AND BLURBS (D3)**.

heuristic evaluation • An informal method for assessing the usability of a Web site, in which three to five expert judges evaluate a site independently, using a list of usability heuristics, or principles. For more information, see Chapter 4 (Involving Customers with Iterative Design).

4

high-fidelity prototype • A finished and highly detailed prototype, rich with typography, colors, and images. Often presented to clients, high-fidelity prototypes are usually created with computer-based tools. A mock-up is a high-fidelity representation of an individual Web page. Compare *low-fidelity prototype* and *medium-fidelity prototype*. For more information, see Chapter 4 (Involving Customers with Iterative Design).

HIP • See *CAPTCHA*.

hit • A metric that measures the number of requests to a Web server. Hits are generally ineffective as a metric because each image file downloaded also counts as a hit. However, hits can be used as a rough approximation of the popularity of a Web site or pages within a Web site. Compare *impressions*.

4

horizontal prototype • A prototype that shows a broad swath of what the eventual Web site will support. A horizontal prototype might show the top-level pages, but without much depth behind them. Compare *vertical prototype*. For more information, see Chapter 4 (Involving Customers with Iterative Design).

hortal • Horizontal portal, a portal that covers a broad range of interests and topics. We hope this terrifying-sounding term never becomes mainstream. This term should not be confused with the art nouveau architect Victor Horta, or the *Star Trek* species known as *horta*. Compare *vortal*.

HTML • HyperText Markup Language, the information that represents the content on a Web page, as well as how the content is displayed.

H5

HTTP • HyperText Transfer Protocol, the means by which HTML Web pages are transferred from a Web server to a Web browser. For more information, see PERSISTENT CUSTOMER SESSIONS (H5).

E6

HTTPS • An encrypted and secure form of HTTP, typically used for financial transactions on the Web. HTTPS is implemented as *HTTP* on top of *SSL*. For more information, see SECURE CONNECTIONS (E6).

human-computer interaction • See *HCI*.

human interactive proof (HIP) • See *CAPTCHA*.

hypertext • Units of information connected and associated with other units. An instance of such an association is called a *link* or *hypertext link*. The most pervasive form of hypertext is the Web, though it is by no means the only form.

HyperText Markup Language • See *HTML*.

HyperText Transfer Protocol • See *HTTP*.

I

D10

I18N • Abbreviation for *internationalization*. The *18* comes from the fact that there are 18 letters between the initial *i* and the final *n* in the word *internationalization*. Compare *L10N*. For more information, see INTERNATIONALIZED AND LOCALIZED CONTENT (D10).

H5

identification • Something that states who someone is. One form of identification is a user name. Compare *authentication*. For more information, see PERSISTENT CUSTOMER SESSIONS (H5).

IE • Internet Explorer, Microsoft's standard Web browser. Typically followed by a version number, such as IE4 or IE5.5.

IIS • Internet Information Server, Microsoft's standard Web server. See also *Apache*.

image map • An image on a Web page whose individual parts can be clicked on to take visitors to other Web pages. Image maps can be either on the client side (where the Web *browser* processes the mouse click) or on the server side (where the Web *server* processes the mouse click). Client-side image maps are usually faster to process and provide better accessibility than server-side maps.

Implementation phase • The fifth phase of Web development, following Production, in which a software development team creates the HTML, images, database tables, and software necessary for a polished and fully functional Web site that can be rolled out and used by its target customers. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites). See also *Discovery phase*, *Exploration phase*, *Refinement phase*, *Production phase*, *Launch phase*, and *Maintenance phase*.

impressions • The number of times people see a specific advertisement. Compare *hit*.

index • 1. See *directory*. 2. The data gathered during a search engine Web crawl.

informal evaluation • A quick method for evaluating the effectiveness of a Web site. Typically, five to ten people representative of target customers help critique a prototype by trying to carry out some tasks from the task analysis.

information architecture • The way information is organized and presented on a Web site. From a usability standpoint, information architecture involves understanding how customers name things, how they categorize and group objects, how they navigate through information, and how they search for information. From an implementation standpoint, information architecture involves creating a structure that scales, or one that can grow as you add more content. Sometimes called *information design*. For more information, see Chapter 4 (Involving Customers with Iterative Design) and Pattern Group B (Creating a Navigation Framework).

information design • See *information architecture*.

information scent • The perceived proximity to desired information, delivered by cues such as text, link names, images, headings, grouping, page layout, and previous pages seen. For more information, see BROWSABLE CONTENT (B2), HOMEPAGE PORTAL (C1), and DESCRIPTIVE, LONGER LINK NAMES (K9).

interactive prototype • A computer-based prototype that is generated to give clients and customers a general understanding of what the completed product should feel like and what it will be capable of doing. See also *wire frame*. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites).

intercept research • A method of recruiting participants to a research study by popping up a short questionnaire on a Web site to a random sample of visitors or to visitors who perform a targeted action on the site (for example, they reach a particular page or leave the site). Intercept research is often used for qualifying

research participants for more in-depth research. For more information, see Appendix E (Online Research).

interlaced image • An image that, when loading, appears blurry at first and then is progressively refined, allowing customers to see the image before it fully loads. **L2** Compare *progressive-scan image*. For more information, see FAST-LOADING IMAGES (L2).

internationalization • The process of making software support different languages, dates and times, currencies, weights and measures, and number formats. Sometimes abbreviated *I18N*. Compare *localization*. For more information, see INTERNATIONALIZED AND LOCALIZED CONTENT (D10).

Internet Explorer • See *IE*.

Internet Information Server • See *IIS*.

Internet Protocol (IP) • See *TCP/IP*.

Internet service provider (ISP) • A company that sells Internet connections to customers. Some ISPs provide cable modem, DSL, and modem access. Also called *access provider*.

interstitial • A page inserted in the normal flow of a task, typically for advertising purposes.

intranet • A Web site designed to be used internally within a company. Compare *extranet*. For more information, see ENABLING INTRANETS (A11).

inverted-pyramid writing • A common journalistic style in which the most important idea is stated first and the text continues to the least important idea. For more information, see INVERTED-PYRAMID WRITING STYLE (D7).

IP • Internet protocol. See *TCP/IP*.

ISP • See *Internet service provider*.

iterative design • A cyclical design process consisting of three stages: design, prototype, and evaluate. Iterative design is a simple and proven technique for developing useful and usable Web sites. For more information, see Chapter 4 (Involving Customers with Iterative Design). **4**

J

JAR file • A standard way of packaging a collection of Java files into a single file, for faster download. *JAR* stands for *Java archive*.

Java • A general-purpose programming language designed by Sun Microsystems, specifically for network applications. For more information, go to javasoft.com.

Java archive • See *JAR file*.

JavaScript • A scripting language designed specifically for Web pages that can, among other things, control the look of the page through the *Document Object Model*.

JavaServer Pages • See *JSP*.

Joint Photographic Experts Group • See *JPEG*.

JPEG • (pronounced “jay-peg”) Joint Photographic Experts Group, a widely supported file format for saving images with many colors, usually photographs. Sometimes seen as *JPG*. See also *GIF*, *PNG*, and *SVG*. For more information, see FAST-LOADING IMAGES (L2). **L2**

JSP • JavaServer Pages, a technology created by Sun Microsystems that combines HTML and Java code. The code is executed when a site visitor makes a request, enabling the creation of dynamically generated HTML. JSP uses Java servlet technology. Compare *ASP* (definition 1), a competing technology from Microsoft; and *PHP*, a similar Perl-based technology.

jump menu • A navigation menu that expands when it's needed and collapses when it's not. For more information, see JUMP MENUS (K16).

K

kbps • Kilobits per second.

keyword • A significant, illustrative word that describes something about the content or services offered by a Web site.

L

L10N • Abbreviation for *localization*. The *10* comes from the fact that there are ten letters between the initial *l* and the final *n* in the word *localization*. Compare *I18N*. For more information, see INTERNATIONALIZED AND LOCALIZED CONTENT (D10).

language • A common vocabulary that allows people to coordinate action.

latency • The amount of time it takes to transfer data from one point to another. Latency should not be confused with *bandwidth*. Here's how they relate to one another: The number of lanes in a highway can be considered the bandwidth, and the amount of time it takes to get from one city to another is the latency. In some cases, increasing the number of lanes will decrease the latency, but clearly, this will work only up to a certain point.

Launch phase • The sixth phase of Web development, following Implementation, in which the finished Web site is made available to its intended customers. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites). See also *Discovery phase*, *Exploration phase*, *Refinement phase*, *Production phase*, *Implementation phase*, and *Maintenance phase*.

lead • The first few paragraphs of a story or longer text. The lead reinforces the headline and entices the visitor to read more. For more information, see INVERTED-PYRAMID WRITING STYLE (D7).

link-based floating window • A floating window that appears when customers click on a link. Compare *automatic floating window*. For more information, see FLOATING WINDOWS (H6).

link rot • The problem of a link on your Web site becoming invalid because your site is out of date or the operator of an external site has changed the content of the page or decommissioned the page address without your knowledge. For more information, see EXTERNAL LINKS (K8).

localization • The process of redesigning a Web interface and translating content to support a local culture. Sometimes abbreviated *L10N*. Compare *internationalization*. For more information, see INTERNATIONALIZED AND LOCALIZED CONTENT (D10).

lossless compression • Reduction in the size of an image file without any loss in image quality. Compare *lossy compression*. For more information, see FAST-LOADING IMAGES (L2).

lossy compression • Reduction in the size of an image file that results in some loss of image quality. Compare *lossless compression*. For more information, see FAST-LOADING IMAGES (L2).

L2

low-fidelity prototype • A quick and informal prototype of a Web site design, often created by sketching on paper, using common art supplies. A low-fidelity prototype contains few details, focusing instead on high-level ideas. It is typically done in the early stages of design. Compare *medium-fidelity prototype* and *high-fidelity prototype*. For more information, see Chapter 4 (Involving Customers with Iterative Design).

4

M

Macromedia Flash • See *Flash*.

maintenance document • A document that details how to maintain a completed Web site. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites).

5

Maintenance phase • The final phase of Web development, following Launch, in which the development team supports the existing site by fixing bugs and making minor improvements, gathers and analyzes metrics for success, and prepares for the next redesign. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites). See also *Discovery phase*, *Exploration phase*, *Refinement phase*, *Production phase*, *Implementation phase*, and *Launch phase*.

5

mbps • Megabits per second.

m-commerce • Mobile e-commerce, such as purchasing items through a mobile phone or PDA.

medium-fidelity prototype • A cleaned-up prototype that gives a feel for the final product without showing too many details, such as typeface, color, and images. Medium-fidelity prototypes are typically done in the early stages of design. Unlike low-fidelity prototypes, they are usually presented to clients. Compare *low-fidelity prototype* and *high-fidelity prototype*. For more information, see Chapter 4 (Involving Customers with Iterative Design).

4

mental model • The way a person believes a system works. People who have used computers extensively, for example, know that most computers consist of a central processing unit (CPU), a monitor, a hard drive, and a keyboard. An engineer will have a more detailed mental model; a novice may have a much simpler (and possibly incorrect) mental model. Usability problems often occur when a customer's mental model does not match the actual workings of a system. The mental model helps set expectations, making the system predictable and understandable.

meta-information • Additional information about content, but not part of the content. Examples of meta-information include the author, the creation time, the last modification time, and the type of information, such as document, image, or audio file. Meta-information is sometimes encoded within <meta> tags.

<meta> tag • A marker in a file that indicates to software applications, including search engine crawlers, what a site or page contains. <Meta> tags are used on all Web pages to provide additional keywords not included in the text, including synonyms, phrases, and language translations. A <meta> tag is often stored with

but is separate from the content it represents. Here's a sample <meta> tag representing the keywords on a Web page:

```
<meta name="keywords" content="chocolate,candy,treats,truffles">
```

For more information, see WRITING FOR SEARCH ENGINES (D6).

metrics for success • Measurements to determine whether the design team has reached its goals and requirements. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites).

mock-up • A high-fidelity representation of a Web page that shows exactly how the page will appear. Usually produced with a graphics application such as Adobe Photoshop, mock-ups are not interactive. Mock-ups contain images, icons, typography, and sophisticated color schemes. Unlike schematics, mock-ups have graphic design that is meant to be taken literally. In some cases, mock-ups are the final deliverable of a design project, perhaps accompanied by written guidelines or specifications.

moderated forum • A forum in which messages are filtered and processed by one or more moderators that must approve all messages to make sure that they follow the established rules and norms. Compare *unmoderated forum*. For more information, see COMMUNITY CONFERENCE (A3).

Mozilla • See *Netscape*.

N

navigation design • The design of methods to help customers find their way around the information structure of a Web site. Navigation design is one part of information architecture. Compare *graphic design*.

Navigator • See *Netscape*.

NDA • See *nondisclosure agreement*.

Netscape • One of the original Web browser companies, now owned by America Online. The term *Netscape* is typically used to refer to the Mozilla or Navigator browser.

network effect • An increase in benefit as more individuals use a particular service. For more information, see NONPROFITS AS NETWORKS OF HELP (A5).

newsletter • A periodic e-mail message sent from a Web site to self-selected customers, informing them of special news, offers, deals, and so on. Compare *alert* and *focused advertisement*. For more information, see E-MAIL SUBSCRIPTIONS (E2).

nondisclosure agreement (NDA) • A legal document specifying that the signer agrees not to discuss any aspect of your product or services with others.

O

open-source software • Software that is distributed with the source code (the files used to construct the software in the first place), with few limitations on what others can do with the source code.

P

p2p • 1. Path to profitability, a business term referring to the strategy needed for companies to become profitable and self-sustaining. 2. See *peer-to-peer architecture*.

page template • See *template*.

participant • A friendly term for someone who helps test an interface design. Meant to replace the not-so-friendly term *subject*, which more and more research disciplines are discarding.

pattern • A design rule that communicates insight into a design problem, capturing the essence of the problem and its solution in a compact form. Design patterns form a language, or common vocabulary, that allows articulation of an infinite variety of Web designs. Patterns are a powerful conceptual framework for building compelling and effective Web sites that are easy to use.

B9 M1

PDA • Personal digital assistant, a small computing appliance for storing personal information. More and more PDAs include wireless connections, making Web access through these small devices possible. For more information, see SITE ACCESSIBILITY (B9) and MOBILE SCREEN SIZING (M1).

PDF • Portable Document Format, a common file format for documents. Compare *PostScript*.

peer-to-peer architecture • Sometimes abbreviated *p2p*, peer-to-peer architecture is a communications model in which all customers are at the same level and have the same access to content and capabilities. A common example of peer-to-peer architecture is Skype, a free telephone application using Voice over Internet Protocol (VoIP). Many people believe peer-to-peer architecture will become more important in the years to come. Compare *client-server architecture*.

periodic backups • Backups of the entire Web site that are stored far away from the building that contains the Web server.

Perl • A programming language often used as part of the Common Gateway Interface.

H5

persistent cookie • A cookie that is stored on the customer's hard drive, allowing a Web site to track that customer over a relatively long period of time. Compare *session cookie*. For more information, see PERSISTENT CUSTOMER SESSIONS (H5).

H5

persistent customer session • A Web session that lets the Web server remember a customer for a relatively long period of time. Compare *temporary customer session*. For more information, see PERSISTENT CUSTOMER SESSIONS (H5).

3

persona • A detailed profile of a potential customer, including name, home address, background, and hobbies. The goal in creating personas is to make each customer seem as real as possible. Compare *profile*. For more information, see Chapter 3 (Knowing Your Customers: Principles and Techniques).

personal digital assistant • See *PDA*.

D4

personalization • A service-driven process that tailors Web pages to individuals or groups of individuals. Two examples of personalization are having a customer's name on a Web page, and remembering a previously entered mailing address. Personalization makes use of information gathered both explicitly (through customization) and implicitly (such as through server log files and previous purchases). Personalization is typically done on the Web server through dynamically generated HTML. Compare *customization*. For more information, see PERSONALIZED CONTENT (D4).

phishing • A form of fraud in which scammers try to trick people into giving up sensitive information, such as account names, passwords, and credit card numbers. Phishing is typically implemented by scammers sending fake e-mails purportedly from legitimate entities such as banks, directing victims to a Web site that looks like the legitimate Web site but is actually a copy that simply stores victims' information. Compare *spam*. For more information, see PREVENTING PHISHING SCAMS (E9).

PHP • PHP: Hypertext Preprocessor (yes, the name is part of the acronym), a technology that mixes HTML and Perl code. The code is executed when a site visitor makes a request, enabling the creation of dynamically generated HTML. Compare *ASP* (definition 1), a competing technology from Microsoft; and *JSP*, a similar Java-based technology.

pilot test • A quick trial of a proposed evaluation method, such as a survey or a usability test, performed by coworkers and friends, to help solve problems in wording or procedure. For more information, see Appendix A (Running Usability Evaluations).

PKI • See *public key infrastructure*.

plug-in • An application that can be embedded into a Web browser. Examples of popular plug-ins include Adobe Acrobat Reader (for PDF files) and Shockwave Flash.

PNG • (pronounced "ping") Portable Network Graphics, a format for storing images designed specifically for transport across networks. PNG was once not widely supported by Web browsers. See also *GIF*, *JPEG*, and *SVG*. For more information, see FAST-LOADING IMAGES (L2).

pop-under • A pop-up window that is positioned under the customer's browser window so that the customer will not see it until the browser is closed.

pop-up window • A small window that appears in a Web browser, often containing advertising messages or definitions of a term. Pop-ups are created with JavaScript. For more information, see FLOATING WINDOWS (H6).

Portable Document Format • See *PDF*.

Portable Network Graphics • See *PNG*.

portal • A major Web site designed for a specific audience that uses it to enter the Web, such as America Online (AOL). Portals contain a broad range of content and often make extensive use of customization and personalization. See also *hortal* and *vortal*.

PostScript • A relatively old but common file format for documents that is understood by many printers, typically with the file extension *ps*, as in *printout.ps*. Compare *PDF*.

principle • A high-level concept that guides the entire design process and helps maintain focus.

process • A well-defined series of steps for accomplishing something. For the purposes of this book, a process is how principles are put into practice.

process data • Qualitative data collected in evaluations, giving an overall gestalt of what works and what doesn't. Compare *bottom-line data*. For more information,

- 4** see Chapter 4 (Involving Customers with Iterative Design) and Appendix A (Running Usability Evaluations).

Production phase • The fourth phase of Web development, following Refinement, in which a fully interactive prototype and/or a design specification are created. Some design firms use the term *production* to mean the actual creation of the Web site—what we have termed *implementation*. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites). See also *Discovery phase*, *Exploration phase*, *Refinement phase*, *Implementation phase*, *Launch phase*, and *Maintenance phase*.

5 **professional respondent** • A focus group member who makes money on the side by participating in group after group.

profile • 1. On a Web site, details about a customer, including information explicitly provided by that customer (such as an e-mail address) and information implicitly collected (such as which Web pages the person has seen). Profiles are used for personalization. 2. In the Discovery phase of Web development, a detailed narrative describing an individual. Some profiles are short; others can be long and descriptive. Some profiles are made up in the imagination of the design team; others are based on actual people. Here's an example: "Gail is a 16-year-old teenager interested in reading and talking about insects. She wants to learn more about how to collect insects and how to take care of them. She started using a computer only recently and is new to the Web, but she is a quick learner and eager to learn more." Compare *persona*.

L2 **progressive-scan image** • An image that loads from top to bottom. Compare *interlaced image*. For more information, see FAST-LOADING IMAGES (L2).

protocol • A formal and precise definition of what kind of information is transferred and how it is transferred between two or more parties. HTTP is an example of a protocol.

prototype • A first cut at a functional model of a user interface such as a Web site. Prototypes include site maps, storyboards, schematics, mock-ups, and HTML prototypes. We use the term *interactive prototype* to refer to a prototype that clients can use on a computer. See also *low-fidelity prototype*, *medium-fidelity prototype*, and *high-fidelity prototype*.

proxy • An intermediate computer between the Web server and the end customer's Web browser. Typical uses of proxies are to cache Web pages for multiple customers and to act as a firewall.

ps • See *PostScript*.

A3 **pseudonym** • The false name that a person who wants to hide his or her true identity assumes within a given community. For more information, see COMMUNITY CONFERENCE (A3).

psychographics • The beliefs and personality traits of customers. Compare *demographics*.

public key infrastructure (PKI) • A technology for encryption on the Internet.

Python • A programming language sometimes used as part of the Common Gateway Interface.

Q

quality assurance • The process of testing all code, graphics, and HTML code thoroughly so that the Web site works as intended and downloads quickly.

question bias • Skewing of a research result because the wording of questions leads people to answer in a certain way. For more information, see Appendix E (Online Research).

R

Really Simple Syndication • See *RSS*.

red-green deficiency • A form of color vision deficiency characterized by the inability to distinguish between red and green. Red-green deficiency affects mostly males. For more information, see Chapter 3 (Knowing Your Customers: Principles and Techniques) and SITE ACCESSIBILITY (B9).

Refinement phase • The third phase of Web site development, following Exploration, in which the design team polishes the navigation, layout, and flow of the selected design. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites). See also *Discovery phase*, *Exploration phase*, *Production phase*, *Implementation phase*, *Launch phase*, and *Maintenance phase*.

reliable data • Results that would be found consistently if you ran a survey or a usability test over and over with the same type of audience under the same conditions.

remote usability research/testing • Online recruitment and usability testing of a Web site, often with many participants. For more information, see Appendix A (Running Usability Evaluations) and Appendix E (Online Research).

response time • The time it takes a customer to initiate an action when given a stimulus. Response times on the order of 100 milliseconds are needed for things like dragging icons and typing text. Response times on the order of 1 second (1,000 milliseconds) are required to maintain an uninterrupted flow of thought when completing a routine action, such as clicking on a button.

RIA • See *Rich Internet Application*.

Rich Internet Application (RIA) • A Web application that provides a high level of interactivity and functionality similar to a traditional desktop application. AJAX is one set of technologies that enables such applications.

rollout • The official deployment of a completed Web site. See also *Launch phase*.

rollover • A graphical icon that changes when the mouse moves over it. Currently, rollovers require visitors to have JavaScript activated in their Web browsers. Compare *tool tip*.

RSS (Really Simple Syndication) • A way of syndicating the content of one Web site on other sites. RSS makes it easy for other Web sites to take summaries of your content and show them on their Web sites, helping to make your content available and increasing traffic to your Web site. RSS also makes it easy for people to track updates and see what new content you have on your Web site. For more information, see BLOGS (A12).

S

sample bias • Skewing of a research result because the composition of participants does not accurately reflect the demographics or psychographics of the target customers. For more information, see Appendix E (Online Research).

Scalable Vector Graphics • See *SVG*.

scale • A measure of how well something works if it increases in size, such as how well an information architecture performs when lots more information is added to a Web site compared to what it was originally designed for, or whether a Web server works as well for 10,000 customers as it does for many fewer customers.

scenario • A story rich in context that focuses more on what people will do than on how they will do it. Also called *use case*. For more information, see Chapters 3 (Knowing Your Customers: Principles and Techniques) and 4 (Involving Customers with Iterative Design).

schematic • A representation of the content that will appear on an individual Web page. Schematics are usually devoid of images, though they may indicate with a label where an image should be placed. Unlike mock-ups, schematics typically do not make heavy use of color, typography, and graphics. Compare *site map* and *storyboard*. For more information, see Chapters 4 (Involving Customers with Iterative Design) and 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites).

screen reader • A special hardware device or software program, designed to assist people with impaired vision, that takes all the text on a page and uses computer-based speech synthesis to read it out. For more information, see **SITE ACCESSIBILITY (B9)**.

scroll wheel • A small dial on a mobile device that lets people move the virtual window up or down in the physical window. Also called *track wheel*.

search engine optimization (SEO) • Strategies and techniques for ensuring that a site is listed close to the top of search results for particular terms that are important to drive customer traffic to a site.

searching • One of two major strategies that visitors use to find information on a Web site. Searching makes use of local or Internet-wide search engines. Compare *browsing*. For more information, see Pattern Group J (Making Site Search Fast and Relevant).

Secure Electronic Transaction • See *SET*.

Secure Sockets Layer • See *SSL*.

SEO • See *search engine optimization*.

server • A centralized repository of information or other resources, usually a Web server. Clients send requests to servers, and servers send results back to clients. Compare *client* (definition 1). See also *client-server architecture*.

servlet • A small Java-based application that runs on a server, commonly used in JSP pages. Servlets are similar in concept to the Common Gateway Interface.

session cookie • A cookie that temporarily stores the identity of a person. When a customer closes his or her Web browser, the session cookie is deleted, making it impossible to track people over long periods of time. Compare *persistent cookie* and *session ID*. For more information, see **PERSISTENT CUSTOMER SESSIONS (H5)**.

session ID • A string that temporarily stores the identity of a customer in a Web address. Compare *session cookie*. For more information, see PERSISTENT CUSTOMER SESSIONS (H5).

SET • Secure Electronic Transaction, a relatively new technology supporting secure financial transactions on the Internet.

shopping cart/bag • A common mechanism, often symbolized by an icon that pictures a shopping cart, for helping customers on the Web keep track of what they want before they finalize a purchase. For more information, see SHOPPING CART (F3).

shrinking • An approach to reducing the file size of an image in which the entire image is resized. Compare *compressing* and *cropping*. For more information, see FAST-LOADING IMAGES (L2).

Simple Object Access Protocol • See *SOAP*.

site map • A high-level diagram showing the overall structure of a site. A site map is used primarily to reflect the information structure of the site, as it is being built, and to a limited extent it shows the navigation structure. Compare *story-board* and *schematic*. For more information, see Chapters 4 (Involving Customers with Iterative Design) and 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites), and SITE MAP (K17).

SOAP • Simple Object Access Protocol, a way of making requests and returning responses to a Web service, typically using XML. SOAP lets organizations create distributed applications over the Web. See also *WSDL*.

solution diagram • Part of a Web design pattern; a drawing that captures the essence of the pattern in graphical form.

spam • Unwanted and often unsolicited e-mail, often related to advertising. The term comes from a Monty Python skit. Compare *phishing*.

specification document • A detailed document, also called a *spec*, that attempts to describe the intent of a design exhaustively and precisely. The specification document contains a set of exact instructions about how to build a site, usually accompanied by an interactive prototype. Directed toward developers who will implement the site, the specification document gives instructions for how to extrapolate from the prototype to the finished site. Compare *guidelines*. For more information, see Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites).

spider • See *crawler*.

splash screen • An opening screen, often heavy with multimedia, shown before the homepage. Splash screens are often implemented with Flash and are frequently of little value.

SSL • Secure Sockets Layer, a form of encryption designed specifically for Web browsers, with the goal of maintaining the security and integrity of information transferred on the Web. SSL is typically used for e-commerce transactions, such as sending credit card information to a Web site. You can tell that you're using SSL if the URL begins with *https://* instead of just *http://*. For more information, see SECURE CONNECTIONS (E6).

statistical validity • A standard for evaluating a study in which it is determined that the study actually measures what it claims to, and that no logical errors have been made in the conclusions drawn from the data. Having enough research participants in a usability study and getting a high enough response rate in a survey are important to achieving validity.

stickiness • The measure of a Web site's ability to retain visitors and drive repeat visits.

storyboard • A sequence of sketches depicting how a customer would accomplish a given task. Typically depicting low-fidelity representations of Web pages, a storyboard is often accompanied by a narrative describing customer tasks. Storyboards are typically not presented to anyone outside the design team, but are used to construct the walk-throughs presented to clients. A walk-through can be thought of as a medium-fidelity or high-fidelity storyboard. Compare *site map* and *schematic*. See also *flow* (definition 1). For more information, see Chapters 3 (Knowing Your Customers: Principles and Techniques), 4 (Involving Customers with Iterative Design), and 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites).

3
4
5

streaming • A method for data transfer, in which small portions of a file are continuously sent to a computer, instead of all at once. The advantage of streaming media is that visitors can view the file as they receive it, instead of having to wait until the entire file is downloaded. Streaming is a common technique used for video and audio files.

style guide • A list of rules for how to spell common words and phrases so that a Web site will have consistent spelling and word usage. A style guide may also specify fonts, colors, and positioning of common design elements (for example, logos). One of Addison-Wesley's styles, for example, is to spell *Web site* as two words, with a capital W. The term appears that way throughout this book.

subsite • A major portion of a Web site in which the individual pages are strongly related in content and navigation.

SVG • Scalable Vector Graphics, an XML-based graphics format supporting the creation of dynamic images. Site visitors can pan and zoom in on SVG images, for example. SVG holds promise for products beyond the desktop computer, such as handheld devices, interactive television, large wall-sized displays, and even printing, because of the way the graphics data is stored. See also *GIF*, *JPEG*, and *PNG*.

synchronous communication • A communications setup in which all parties have to be online simultaneously and interaction takes place in real time. Compare *asynchronous communication*. For more information, see COMMUNITY CONFERENCE (A3).

A3

T

T-1 • A piece of hardware needed for a network connection. The term is commonly used to refer to a type of Internet connection provided by telephone companies. T-1 lines transfer data at 1.5 megabits per second and are typically leased by ISPs and businesses.

tag cloud • A visual depiction of content tags used on a Web site. Often, more frequently used tags are depicted in a larger font or otherwise emphasized, while the displayed order is generally alphabetical.

target customer • See *customer*.

task • A specific goal that a customer wants to accomplish when using a Web site, such as sending an online birthday card to a grandparent, or finding and purchasing the best digital camera for less than \$500.

task analysis • The process of identifying common tasks that customers will perform on a Web site.

task and customer analysis • An analysis performed by the design team to articulate who the customers are, what they will do on the Web site, the things they act on, and the things they need to know. For more information, see Chapter 3 (Knowing Your Customers: Principles and Techniques).

TCP/IP • Transmission Control Protocol/Internet Protocol, the core set of protocols that control how data is transferred over the Internet. HTTP, used for transferring Web pages, is built on top of TCP/IP.

technology-centered design • A design strategy that results in a Web site overloaded with animations, audio, and streaming video banners, built with little up-front research about business and customer needs. Compare *company-centered design*, *customer-centered design*, and *designer-centered design*. For more information, see Chapter 1 (Customer-Centered Web Design: More Than a Good Idea).

template • A sample HTML file that contains the basic structure, layout, and scripts for a set of Web pages of a Web site. Templates typically contain the navigation elements global to the Web site, as well as sections that can be edited for specific local navigation and specific content. Templates are used to ensure consistency throughout a site. For more information, see PAGE TEMPLATES (D1), CONTENT MODULES (D2), and Chapter 5 (Processes for Developing Customer-Centered Sites).

temporary customer session • A Web session that lets the Web server remember a customer for only a short period of time, usually until the customer closes the Web browser. Compare *persistent customer session*. For more information, see PERSISTENT CUSTOMER SESSIONS (H5).

think-aloud protocol • An experimental setup in which participants say out loud what they're thinking as they use a test Web site, in order to give site designers an idea of how customers will use the site. Also called *verbal protocol*. For more information, see Chapter 4 (Involving Customers with Iterative Design).

thumbnail • A small version of an image that is linked to a larger version. Clicking on a thumbnail brings up the larger image on-screen. For more information, see LOW NUMBER OF FILES (L1) and FAST-LOADING IMAGES (L2).

tool tip • A piece of text that appears when the mouse cursor hovers over a button or an image. Compare *rollover*.

track wheel • See *scroll wheel*.

trail marker • See *bread crumb*.

Transmission Control Protocol/Internet Protocol • See *TCP/IP*.

tutorial • An online, instruction-based class used for training.

two-factor authentication • A security alternative to simple passwords in which a person must sign in using a physical object (such as a smart card or a special

E9

key-chain fob, like a small USB device) in addition to entering a password. For more information, see PREVENTING PHISHING SCAMS (E9).

U

UI • See *user interface*.

undersampling bias • Skewing of a research result because there are not enough participants to have a statistically valid sample. For more information, see Appendix E (Online Research).

Uniform Resource Locator • See *URL*.

unmoderated forum • A free-for-all discussion in which anything goes. People can say whatever they want, and it is up to the members of the community to enforce any rules and social norms. Compare *moderated forum*. For more information, see COMMUNITY CONFERENCE (A3).

A3

up-selling • Promoting products that have more features and benefits (and cost more) than those that a customer wants to purchase. Compare *cross-selling*. For more information, see SHOPPING CART (F3) and CROSS-SELLING AND UP-SELLING (G2).

F3 G2

URL • Uniform Resource Locator, the official Web word for *address*. Any address beginning with *http://* is a URL.

use case • See *scenario*.

user-centered design • An effort pioneered in the 1980s for engineering useful and usable computer systems. We have broadened and expanded this concept for Web design into *customer-centered design*. For more information, see Chapter 1 (Customer-Centered Web Design: More Than a Good Idea).

1

user-created content • Content that site customers share with other customers.

user experience • See *customer experience*.

user interface (UI) • The part of a system with which a customer interacts. See also *GUI*.

V

value proposition • A brief statement of what a Web site offers to target customers. For more information, see UP-FRONT VALUE PROPOSITION (C2).

C2

value ranking • The method that a search engine uses to order the different results it returns for a particular search. For more information, see GRASSROOTS INFORMATION SITE (A6).

A6

verbal protocol • See *think-aloud protocol*.

vertical prototype • A prototype that implements only a few key Web pages along with the path for completing a particular task. Creation of a vertical prototype is appropriate when a complex feature is poorly understood or needs to be explored further. Compare *horizontal prototype*. For more information, see Chapter 4 (Involving Customers with Iterative Design).

4

Virtual Private Network • See *VPN*.

virtual testing • Evaluation of a Web site in which a few select customers see a proposed updated site, and they can be observed to see what they do compared to what they do on the regular Web site.

visual design • See *graphic design*.

vortal • Vertical portal, a portal that specializes in a specific topic, such as law or medicine. Compare *hortal*.

VPN • Virtual Private Network, a way of establishing a private communications network on top of a public network. VPNs are typically used within a company to secure e-mail and other services.

W

W3C • World Wide Web Consortium, the group that coordinates protocols and standards used on the Web, including HTTP, HTML, and XML. For more information, go to w3.org.

walk-through • A sequential presentation of Web pages narrated by the designer, who explains what customers will do on each page. Designers can also use a storyboard for a (low-fidelity) walk-through.

WAP • Wireless Application Protocol, used primarily by small devices, such as mobile phones, to access e-mail and the Web. See also *WML*. For more information, see MOBILE SCREEN SIZING (M1).

Web browser • The software used to navigate Web sites from a computer. The two most popular Web browsers are Internet Explorer and Firefox, also called Mozilla. Other browsers include America Online's Web browser, Opera, and the text-based browser Lynx. A Web browser is an example of a client in a client-server architecture.

Web interface guidelines • A checklist to ensure that a final product has no obvious problems. Often these guidelines address only how a Web site is implemented.

Web log • See *blog*.

Web server • A server, such as Apache or IIS, that delivers Web pages upon request.

Web Services Description Language • See *WSDL*.

white space • The area on a page that is intentionally left blank to create a feeling of spaciousness and a more readable design. Most bad designs would benefit from more white space.

widget • An interactive object such as a button or slider.

wire frame • A simple but functional interactive prototype of a Web site. Typically a wire frame contains text, layout, links, and overall structure, but few if any graphics.

Wireless Application Protocol • See *WAP*.

Wireless Markup Language • See *WML*.

within-groups experiment • An experiment in which there is one group of test participants, each assigned to the same condition. For example, when testing two Web sites, each participant uses both sites. Compare *between-groups experiment*. For more information, see Appendix A (Running Usability Evaluations).

WML • Wireless Markup Language. A markup language similar to HTML, WML is designed specifically for small devices, such as mobile phones. See also *WAP* and *HDML*. For more information, see MOBILE SCREEN SIZING (M1).

World Wide Web Consortium • See *W3C*.

WSDL • Web Services Description Language, a way of precisely specifying what services a Web service offers. WSDL can also be thought of as an API for a Web service. Each service offered can be accessed through a *SOAP* request.

X

XML • Extensible Markup Language, a standard created by W3C for specifying information formats. Although it is similar to HTML, XML can be extended for use in any domain.

XHTML • Extensible Hypertext Markup Language, a markup language that has the same expressive possibilities as HTML, but a stricter syntax.

